



KEYMER IS KEEN TO QUALIFY FOR THE CANDIDATES, A TOURNAMENT IN WHICH HE IS YET TO MAKE AN APPEARANCE

Able ally: Keymer was a second for Gukesh at the World Championship final last year. DEBASISH BHADURI

explicitly seeped into the way he plays. “I believe chess players are a combination of everything we know. I do believe it increased my knowledge and my horizon.

“Maybe I’ll implement things in my play that I never did before. I think it can help me. But at the same time, he [Gukesh] is a very different player. So I cannot just try to copy him — and I would never try to,” says Keymer.

Having gathered an insider’s perspective on a world title challenge, Keymer is ready to mount one himself.

The first step would be to qualify for the Candidates, a tournament in which he is yet to make an appearance. Keymer is leaving all options open to break that duck.

“The two obvious choices [qualification routes] are Grand Swiss and World Cup. I have played well in all my Grand Swiss tournaments and World Cups. It could have gone even better if there wasn’t a certain Carlsen always stopping you.

I have already won the German Championship. So, in case a tournament like this one [Chennai Grand Masters] goes really well, I might start to play events for the FIDE circuit points,” adds Keymer.

Having successfully navigated the perilous developmental stages, Keymer has positioned himself well for the next phase of his career — where prophecies will be put to the test, promises challenged by the present, and expectations countered by reality.